

Why Did Jesus Fast?

Fasting Executes the Flesh's Declared Position So We Can Receive From God

We found out from the substitutionary and identification teachings that fasting does not move God. God does not need to be moved. Fasting moves us into a position to receive from God because fasting executes a substitutionary truth of what Jesus is in our life.

We found out that if Christ is in me, my spirit is life. It is seated with Jesus because of righteousness. But my body has been declared dead.

In the same way that praying in the Holy Ghost, confession, and meditation execute the position my spirit has been declared, seated with Jesus, fasting executes the position my body has been declared, which is dead.

Romans 8:10 says:

"And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness."

We know this body is not literally dead yet. The truth fasting executes is a mortification truth. As far as the motions of sin, the forces of the flesh, and all its lusts are concerned, as far as the flesh being able to dominate the operation of your inner man where the Holy Ghost lives, God has given you power through the rebirth and baptism of the Holy Spirit to mortify the flesh, to put it to death so it does not dominate you, but you dominate it.

Fasting executes the position our flesh has been declared: dead.

Prayer and Fasting Deal With the Unbelief That Keeps Mountains in Place

In Matthew 17, the devil would not come out because of the disciples' unbelief. Jesus said that if they fasted, they would deal with that unbelief.

Then in Matthew 9, when the disciples of John asked Jesus why His disciples did not fast, He said, "The day will come when I will go away and establish a new covenant. Unfortunately, I must leave you in the old wineskin and the old garment, which is this flesh. It has not yet been glorified. One day there will be the sound of the trumpet, and it will go from corruptible to incorruptible. But meanwhile you are wearing a body that is dying and can be corrupted."

He said, "In that day, when I establish a new covenant, you will fast." Do men put new wine in old bottles? In other words, "I have to leave you in this old wineskin, even though you are born again in your spirit. But in that day you will fast, because fasting has the same effect on the old garment

and the old wineskin as if you had gone out and bought a brand-new one. It preserves it until it is glorified."

Then we went to Isaiah 58 and found out that if we do not clothe the naked, feed the hungry, invite the lost into God's house, and break every yoke off of ourselves, then when we decide to fast we have chosen not to hide ourselves from our own flesh.

Isaiah 58 says the fast God has chosen is the one where you hide not yourself from your own flesh. The moment you decide to fast is the moment you decide you are no longer going to hide from your own flesh: the motions of the flesh loose on the inside of you that keep you from evangelizing the lost, feeding the hungry, breaking yokes, and setting captives free.

It deals with that passive, indifferent attitude that is satisfied to go from church to church and sit there as long as nobody bothers you about doing any more than you are doing.

The moment you decide to fast, you put that outer man to death. You execute a positional truth of mortification. You brace the old wineskin, and you quit hiding from your failures.

That positional truth is all dealing with the flesh.

Jesus' Forty-Day Fast Was Not to Weaken Him but to Establish Our Standing

Here is why all of it works. For a long time I could not understand this, and we touched on it Friday night. Now we are going to capsulize Jesus' fast one more time.

Matthew 4:1-11 says:

"Then was Jesus led up of the Spirit into the wilderness to be tempted of the devil.
And when he had fasted forty days and forty nights, he was afterward an hungred.
And when the tempter came to him, he said, If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread.
But he answered and said, It is written, Man shall not live by bread alone, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of God.
Then the devil taketh him up into the holy city, and setteth him on a pinnacle of the temple,
And saith unto him, If thou be the Son of God, cast thyself down: for it is written, He shall give his angels charge concerning thee:
and in their hands they shall bear thee up, lest at any time thou dash thy foot against a stone.
Jesus said unto him, It is written again, Thou shalt not tempt the Lord thy God.
Again, the devil taketh him up into an exceeding high mountain, and showeth him all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them;
And saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me.
Then saith Jesus unto him, Get thee hence, Satan: for it is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve.
Then the devil leaveth him, and, behold, angels came and ministered unto him."

Jesus fasted forty days and forty nights. That is for you day-fasters only. You say, "I fasted forty days," but you ate at night. He fasted forty days and nights.

When He worshiped God, the devil left Him, and angels came and ministered to Him. I cannot think of anyone I would rather have come into my quarters of fasting and prepare a meal for me to break my fast on than angels.

The more I meditate on this, the more it opens up.

The first thing I could not figure out about Jesus' fast was why the Holy Spirit would lead Him into the wilderness to be tempted by the devil. To me, that seemed to go against every spiritual law I understood God to be. The great prayer says, "Lead us not into temptation," or lead us around the snares of the evil one and deliver us from him. So it did not make much sense to say the Holy Spirit actually led Him into a situation where He would be tempted.

Throughout the years, I asked those who seemed to be something among them. I did not like to spend too much time on these verses because they did not make sense to me, and I could not force a revelation. I did better to leave them alone until I had the capacity to understand them.

Most of the people moving in power gave me almost the same answer:

"Jesus fasted and weakened Himself to a state of great weakness concerning the flesh. It brought Him to the point where He was most susceptible to Satan's temptations."

But that is contrary to everything else the Word says. Jesus said fasting has the same effect on the flesh, or the old wineskin, as if you had gone out and bought a new one. He said when you fast, you choose not to hide yourself from your own flesh, the weaknesses of the flesh that keep you from fulfilling your ministry for God.

When the devil would not come out, Jesus recommended fasting. The disciples asked why they could not cast him out, and He said, "Because of your unbelief." Then He told them how to remedy it: "This kind cometh not out but by prayer and fasting."

Once again, fasting strengthens our stand against the devil. It does not weaken it.

So when they told me Jesus brought Himself to the weakest state of the flesh so He could survive the devil's temptations, that was wrong.

The whole reason Jesus was led into the wilderness for temptation was because it is a substitution-identification truth. In the pattern of things for your salvation, it was necessary for Jesus to withstand the devil solely so that when He withstood him and received that standing from God, He could turn around and give that standing to you.

Then you can boldly stand up and say:

"I have power over all the power of the enemy, and nothing shall by any means hurt me."

Jesus withstood the devil and took that perfect standing He received, then by an act of grace gave it to you. It is actually His standing that you withstand the devil on.

That is why you do not say, "In the name of Roberson, come out." I do not think so.

You say, "In the name of Jesus, come out." What are you saying? "On the standing He gave me when He whipped you in the wilderness as a Man, come out."

And they come out.

Jesus did not fast to weaken Himself. He fasted because He was on an appointment of destiny to receive a portion of the substitutionary, identification standing He was going to give to you.

He fasted for the same reason you fast: to strengthen Himself against the onslaughts of the enemy.

Satan Himself Came Because the Temptation Had to Be Taken to the Maximum

What am I doing when I fast, Brother Roberson?

You are executing the position your flesh has been declared, which is dead, and releasing the standing Jesus has given you in that situation in your life. The more you put the flesh to death, the more you execute the perfect standing Jesus acquired for you when He faced Satan in the wilderness.

This is what makes it work.

Jesus was not tempted by a principality. He was not tempted by a power. He was not tempted by a ruler of darkness or spiritual wickedness in high places.

Ephesians says:

"We wrestle not against flesh and blood, but against principalities, against powers, against the rulers of the darkness of this world, against spiritual wickedness in high places."

But Jesus was not tempted by any of them. The tempter came.

Just like Jesus is the Redeemer and Head of the Church, and underneath Jesus are apostles, prophets, and teachers charged with establishing the canon of Scripture, underneath the chief principality, Satan, are principalities. They are charged with indoctrinating their part of the world to their way of thinking.

This is why the Islamic world tends to think one way, the African mind another, the Oriental mind another, and the Western mind another. The principality in that part of the world has indoctrinated people to think like he thinks.

Directly underneath principalities are powers. In the body of Christ, workings of miracles and gifts of healings are supposed to empower all offices that are empowered by the Holy Ghost to work miracles that manifest God enough to bring a city to its knees. There is supposed to be enough power in the church, like the early church, that they bring people from regions round about and they are healed, and revival is poured out.

Workings of miracles and gifts of healings have been poured out on the church to that measure. We just have not received it.

In Satan's counterfeit, powers supply the power for witchcraft, lying signs and wonders, and stigmata.

Rulers of darkness are the counterfeit for helps and governments. They are a ruling class of spirits that organize hell against invasions of light. Helps and governments organize the whole body of Christ so that if a little believer is born again way out on the outer perimeter, they organize to make sure he has all the nourishment he needs to grow in Christ. That is their job.

Rulers of darkness organize against any onslaughts of light. Jesus said it this way: when an unclean spirit goes out of a man, he goes and gets help, seven spirits more wicked than himself, and they come back to overpower the man. Where did he go for help? To a ruler of darkness, because their job is organization.

Underneath them is divers tongues. The eighth operation of God is where the Holy Ghost baptizes me and gets involved with me personally. God comes down and walks with me as a man. I can pray in tongues as He teaches me one-to-one by the Holy Ghost.

The counterfeit for that is spiritual wickedness in high places, dominating the air below mountaintop level. It is a class of wicked spirit that operates on a direct level with humanity. They are as close as the air you breathe. They are a low-level class of spirits that possess, intimidate, cause diseases, sicknesses, torments, fights, and church splits. Just as the Holy Ghost operates on the direct level of humanity, so does that class of spirit.

But none of those four classes came after Jesus.

Most of you get taken out on the lower level, spiritual wickedness on a level with humanity. They get you fighting over the color of the carpet, fighting with each other, and saying, "He offended me." Most get taken out on that level, much less by the devil organizing a class of spirits against you that rules, or a power coming to take you out, or a principality like Paul faced when a messenger straight from the throne room of hell was assigned to him to bring his ministry to a standstill.

Not many people operate on a level where the devil has to send a principality after them.

But none of those four classes of spiritual wickedness came after Jesus. Satan, the head of all principalities, took time to go after Him.

Why? Because in His temptation, Jesus had to take temptation to the maximum. You cannot understand the pressure put on Him in the wilderness. He fasted to stand against it, to mortify His flesh, to brace Himself. He was getting ready to stand up against the god of this world and everything he had to throw at Him.

Before Satan's fall, he was Lucifer, the anointed cherub that covered. There was mighty Jehovah, the mighty Logos, the second Person in the Godhead, the mighty Holy Ghost, and then the fourth was Lucifer, the anointed cherub that covered. He covered the entire universe and operated just one step underneath Jesus Christ.

Now Jesus had to face him in the wilderness. Jesus fasted forty days in preparation.

Jesus Took Satan's Best Shot in Spirit, Soul, and Body

When Satan came, he pushed the temptation to the maximum. If you have ever been in the lower levels of an insane asylum, you know there are people whose hands have to be tied and who have to remain in restraints around the clock. If you free their hands, they will eat their own dung. If all that is projecting the imagery of Satan's mind, he is morbid. He is sick.

When you play with him, you are playing with a snake. When you go to places that cater to your flesh, you think you are doing yourself a favor. But if you have seen people totally crazy, possessed, obsessed, and enraged, slaughtering whole civilizations, then you begin to understand the pressure Jesus stood against.

If He thought fasting was necessary, what is wrong with you?

When the tempter came, he brought Him to the maximum. He pushed Him to the limit. There was no more he had to give.

Every man, woman, and child born through seven thousand years can know that Jesus took Satan's best shot. Whatever any man has ever had to stand against, Jesus stood against more. The reason is that He turned around and gave you His standing.

When you feel like you are going to fall, the way you enforce His standing in your life is by fasting.

Satan took his best shot. There was no more to test Him with. Satan would return later and attempt again, but he had no more to give. Jesus defeated him.

He defeated him in three areas: spirit, soul, and body.

The first temptation was physical:

"If thou be the Son of God, command that these stones be made bread."

This was the realm of the physical man. It included necessities, disease, sickness, and that whole realm.

In Mark 4, when Satan comes immediately to steal the Word, he uses persecution, affliction, cares of this life, deceitfulness of riches, and lusts of other things. These are the same temptations he used against Jesus.

First, persecution and affliction came in the physical realm. That is the first thing the devil uses against a new believer. He will try disease, lack, and physical pressure to get him to accuse God. If he can take you out in that realm, he does not have to bother with much more.

The second area of temptation is the soul realm. "I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth." The soul is the mind, the will, the intellect, and the emotional faculties. It is the emotional man.

The second area Satan hits is the emotions, the cares of this world. That is when he took Jesus to a pinnacle, handled Him, badgered Him, pushed Him, and accused God of not watching over Him.

"God said He would take care of You, so go ahead and jump."

Satan accused the Word of God to Jesus. He was pressuring Him toward suicide. That is the emotional realm, the cares of this world.

You cannot believe the pressure brought against Him to jump. If a normal believer were in a room and the devil badgered him until he jumped off a building, how would you classify that? Suicide. Jesus took that pressure to the maximum, all the way to suicide and everything between, and withstood him so the devil cannot bowl you over with the cares of this world, torment, and possession.

The third realm is the spirit. The devil knows that about the only thing he can get a man's spirit with, once that man is established in God, is glory, self-exaltation, and money.

That is when Satan took Jesus up into a high mountain. This had to be in the spirit, because you cannot see all the kingdoms of the world from one physical location. The earth is round. Satan showed Him all the kingdoms of the world and their glory. In another place, he said, "These have been given to me, and whomsoever I will I give them."

All the kingdoms of the world had been given to him as the god of this world by Jesus' great-great-grandfather Adam, when Adam turned his authority over to Satan and made him the god of this world.

Satan said, "All these kingdoms are mine, and I give them to whom I choose. If You will turn Your spirit over to me, if You will fall down and worship me like Adam did, I will make You the wealthiest and most powerful man in the world."

The devil will get his beast, but he did not get Jesus.

Jesus said:

"It is written, Thou shalt worship the Lord thy God, and him only shalt thou serve."

In effect, He said, "I am only going to serve God in My humanity, and Him only will I worship. Now get out of here. You are finished."

Then angels came and broke His fast. Then Jesus came out of the wilderness, later died, and gave His standing to me.

So you do not have to fail. If you fail, it is because you do not know how to execute His grace in your life, which is His free standing. He freely set you free from the devil. But if the devil talks you into being bound, you need to know how to execute that positional truth.

Hello, fasting.

Paul's Thorn Shows Grace as the Standing That Must Be Executed

What do you think Paul said?

Satan pushed him to the edge. "God, I do not know how much longer I can take it. A strong principality has been loosed against me. I do not know how long I can take it."

Three times Paul sought God because of the abundance of revelations. God considered him worthy to establish the canon of Scripture, and Satan considered him worthy to be stopped. Because of his abundance of revelations, Satan assigned a principality with one mission: bring Paul's ministry to a standstill.

Three times that principality shook Paul to his knees, and three times God informed him, "My grace is sufficient for thee." The free standing God gave him was sufficient.

Then God showed him the area he was lacking in: "Paul, start rejoicing and worshiping Me in the middle of these things. When you are weak, you will be strong."

That means if this trial strips your dependency off the flesh and places it on the spirit, it will make you strong when you worship God. Then you will execute His standing in your life.

When you fast, you execute the standing over the flesh that Jesus gave you in your life. Paul withstood him.

You can too.

Hard Preaching Is Meant to Move Us Beyond Blame Into Revival

Go to First Corinthians 3.

I want to say this. It is coming up out of my heart, and I do not quite know how to say it. The more I seek my Father, and I know it is the same in your case, the more I love Him. The more I love Him, the more I love people. The more His love grows in you, the more you love people, indifferent to their multitudes of faults and shortcomings.

I know I am hard on you. I know that. That is why I see so many faces come and faces leave.

But until we get you to a place spiritually where you quit blaming other people and circumstances for your problems, we are not going to mature very far. I know I am hard on you.

About half the people here are preachers. If you are called to actively handle the Word of God and preach it, raise your hand. Look at that.

If I am an elder, I am supposed to take charge over you by example. What I do, most of you will do. What I do not do, some of you will still do. That is why Jesus called it thirty, sixty, and one hundredfold.

Thirtyfold means there is still seventy percent of unexplored territory in your life. He called it the good, acceptable, and perfect will. Sowing is acceptable. People do it all the time, like going to a doctor is acceptable. Sixtyfold is still forty shy of the full operation of the Word. But one hundredfold is the manifestation of the Word of God in your life in every single area.

When I challenge you the way I do, I know I have brought condemnation on some of you. I do not mean to do that. The reason I teach and preach the way I do about fasting and prayer is because I am in love with you, not because I hate you.

Yet I know this kind of gospel that I preach is one God has charged me to preach. He has charged me with receiving a revival here in Tulsa. Receiving one. It has already been sent. He has charged me with it.

If receiving a revival is our charge, then if there is no revival raging in the city, He must be calling us to do something nobody is doing. If they were doing it, it would come. So we are still exploring what to do.

When I come across hard, it is not my intention to bring condemnation on you. I am telling you something about Jesus' grace: it is sufficient.

Perfect Standing Saves Us; Mature Obedience Lets Us Receive a Citywide Harvest

You cannot enter heaven on anything but a perfect standing. Jesus gave that to you when He seated your spirit in heavenly places with Christ Jesus. His nature entered your spirit.

I am still wearing a body given to me by the first Adam. Sometimes it is tempted to sin, gets angry, and gives me problems, so I have to mortify it. But my spirit continues to abide in that nature and in the love of God, which keeps pulling my flesh back into line.

Nothing short of the perfect standing He gave you will get you into heaven.

Buddha had good humanistic teachings toward other people. Mahatma Gandhi, when challenged with Christianity, said, "You people do not love each other. Show me more than we have, and I will accept your religion." Gandhi had good humanistic teaching about how to treat people. But he had no access to God outside Jesus Christ. There is none.

Even though Gandhi taught almost a perfect standing toward others humanistically, he could never be good enough to get into heaven or teach you to be good enough. Man had an old nature and had to have a new heart. As long as you have that old nature, you cannot be good enough.

Nothing short of the standing of Jesus Christ will get you into heaven. When you bowed your knee and accepted Jesus Christ, because you could never through works be good enough to be perfect, you received by a free gift a standing that will get you into heaven when your life is over.

If you never went to church or tithed or did anything but acknowledged God as your Savior and had that nature in your spirit, and it never got you to do the other things but was enough for your salvation, my friend, you are still going to heaven.

What we are teaching here are the things that shut down the part of us the devil controls so we can receive revival and take a few million home with us from this area.

Do you want to take a few million people home from Oklahoma to be with you forever? They will come if we can receive a revival. They will come if the heavens open, if the ceiling pulls back and He pours His glory out until wheelchair cases, the deaf, the demon-possessed, and the homosexual community are delivered by the glory of God and cannot wait to get back in His presence.

He has been wanting to pour that out for years. He has charged us with receiving it. This is why I am so hard. I want you to go further than salvation. I want you to receive a revival. I want you to become victorious over everything He has redeemed you from, go on to conquer, and get yourself

a reward.

We want to receive the revival He sent.

None of what I teach is intended to bring condemnation on you. If you never come and pray, never fast, never do anything except come support the church and say, "Yes, I am there for you," and bring people into camp meetings, you are going to get nothing from us but love. I know you are on your way to heaven.

But if you are like me, and you are bound up by the flesh in thirtyfold, how would you know you wanted more unless somebody came along and taught you to be free from the thirty? How would you know you wanted more than sixty unless somebody taught you what is beyond sixty? How would you know a man could even walk in Jesus' standing, which is one hundredfold, unless somebody pushed through and walked in it so you could see what it looks like?

My fear is that I could not get enough information to enter in. I want my day in court.

If I fail, do not let it be because some fool put me in bondage and let me hear only the things I wanted to hear because I gave him money. If I fail, do not let it be because someone put me in a doctrinal holding tank, petted my flesh, and petted my special talents while I was so fleshly it was pathetic, while faithful people stood by silently.

If I fail, please do not let it be because I did not have my day in court. Tell me the truth. Show me how to enter in. Tell me about fasting. Tell me about praying in the Holy Ghost. Tell me about meditating. Tell me about unexplored territory. Tell me what is out there. Then if I fail, let it be because I failed, not because I did not have the information to succeed.

I do not mean to condemn you. I love you. I want to see you enter into heaven with a reward so great that heaven is talking about it. I want you to feast your tired old Pentecostal eyes on thousands of people running to the front to be born again and set free before your passage on this earth is over.

We have a vision.

First Corinthians 3 Separates Foundation, Building, Reward, and Loss

Can I prove these things? Yes.

Go to First Corinthians 3:1:

"And I, brethren, could not speak unto you as unto spiritual, but as unto carnal, even as unto babes in Christ.

I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able.

For ye are yet carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men?"

It looks like Paul had the same problem.

What qualifies carnality? Envy, strife, and divisions. When one says, "I am of this church," and another says, "I go over here," Paul says, "Are you not carnal?"

He continues:

"Who then is Paul, and who is Apollos, but ministers by whom ye believed, even as the Lord gave to every man?

I have planted, Apollos watered; but God gave the increase.

So then neither is he that planteth any thing, neither he that watereth; but God that giveth the increase.

Now he that planteth and he that watereth are one: and every man shall receive his own reward according to his own labour.

For we are labourers together with God: ye are God's husbandry, ye are God's building."

Underline "God's building." You are God's husbandry. You are God's building, and God is the Husbandman working in this building.

Then Paul says:

"According to the grace of God which is given unto me, as a wise masterbuilder, I have laid the foundation, and another buildeth thereon.

But let every man take heed how he buildeth thereupon.

For other foundation can no man lay than that is laid, which is Jesus Christ."

Paul was not saying he had the only revelation for the foundation of the church. He was saying the only foundation is Jesus Christ. Jesus said, "I am the way, the truth, and the life. No man cometh unto the Father, but by Me."

If you are building your religion on any other foundation except Jesus Christ crucified, then you have a false religion. You cannot build on anything but Jesus crucified and resurrected, bearing my sins, my Savior.

Paul goes on:

"Now if any man build upon this foundation gold, silver, precious stones, wood, hay, stubble; Every man's work shall be made manifest: for the day shall declare it, because it shall be revealed by fire; and the fire shall try every man's work of what sort it is. If any man's work abide which he hath built thereupon, he shall receive a reward. If any man's work shall be burned, he shall suffer loss: but he himself shall be saved; yet so as by fire."

Paul is saying, "I am a wise master builder. I have given you the revelation of Jesus Christ crucified. He is the Savior of mankind. You cannot build on any other foundation. But if any man builds on wood, hay, or stubble, if he adds error doctrinally upon that foundation, his works will be tried by a refiner's fire."

It is the same fire referred to when the fan is in His hand and the axe is laid to the root of the tree. You will be baptized with the Holy Ghost and fire.

I would rather let Him burn the dross out of me while I can still receive a reward than have what I would not receive burn up on the day of rewards.

I would rather partake of His ministry now, the ministry of the Holy Ghost and fire, the refiner's fire, where He burns the dross.

Have you ever seen metal purified? They heat it until the dross comes to the top, then scoop it off, leaving the pure gold or iron.

I would rather through fasting, praying, and meditating His Word cut the dead limbs off and partake of the refiner's fire while I can still get a reward for it.

If you do nothing, if you add no foundation, if you do not fulfill your call, He said you will be saved as by fire. Your works will be tried, and when they burn you will have nothing left but salvation.

In substitution-identification truth, Jesus became all these things for me. When I conform to these things, I receive His standing. Anything that keeps you from fulfilling your call in the body of Christ, from putting your brick in the building of God, will be tested. If you fail because of wood, hay, and stubble, if your building crumbles because of false teaching, then on that day when you stand before Jesus to get your reward, the refiner's fire will check everything you have done against everything He has done for you and everything the Word says.

If anything is outside the Word of God and is not true, it will burn up. Your works will burn, and you will be saved as by fire.

Notice: you will not be punished for your failures. You will be rewarded for what is left.

Why? Because Jesus already bore your failure.

Defiling the Temple Means Corrupting God's Building With False Doctrine

First Corinthians 3:16-17 says:

"Know ye not that ye are the temple of God, and that the Spirit of God dwelleth in you?
If any man defile the temple of God, him shall God destroy;
for the temple of God is holy, which temple ye are."

When I was ultra, ultra, ultra-holiness, this was where you could go to hell for putting on a ring. I do not know what they are going to do with Jesus. He wears a whole band of gold around His waist. He does not even bother with His finger.

On the prodigal son, the father placed a ring on his finger. Here he comes all the way back from the hog mire, and his dad is in false teaching. He puts a ring on him, so he loses his salvation right there.

That is how they preached it:

"This is God's temple, which temple you are. If you defile it, He will destroy you."

To holiness people, defiling the temple meant drinking, smoking, chewing, carousing, dancing, swimming, mixed bathing, rings, jewelry, and anything like that. In ultra-holiness, they called swimming "mixed bathing." I thought, no wonder they do not want to do it. Who wants to get in a bathtub with a woman? We later found out they were talking about swimming.

They used the verse about not letting your adorning be outward, with gold and jewelry, but inward, with meekness. What Peter was saying was that the emphasis should not be on the outer man. The emphasis should be on the inner man, developing meekness, joy, love, temperance, and the fruit of the Spirit. He did not really care much what you wore on the outer man as long as you developed the inner man.

But just like then and now, most of the emphasis is put on the outer man.

The defiling of the temple here is not those areas. Paul is saying, "You are the temple of God, and we all have a place to fulfill in His temple. Be careful how you build your ministry in that temple. You cannot lay any other foundation but Jesus Christ, the one already laid. Do not build with false doctrines."

If you build unstable walls in God's temple, such as teaching that the Holy Ghost is not for today or tongues are not for today, your bonfire is going to shock you in the last day.

If you teach against salvation, if you say Jesus Christ is not the only way to God, if you destroy the foundation of salvation, then this temple is holy, and if you defile this temple, everything you defiled in it will be destroyed. If you defile salvation, you will be destroyed with it.

It is much deeper than a cigarette.

If you have emotional problems that will not let you turn loose of a cigarette, the cigarette is not the root of it. The emotional addiction is. The cigarette is not the root; it is one symptom. Anything that defiles the temple is no good. God wants you sanctified wholly, spirit, soul, and body.

What I am telling you is that you can get messed up, and your works can burn, but at least you will make it in as by fire because your failures were laid on Jesus, unless you let the devil take salvation itself out of it.

Let us go on.